

Reform Democrats of the New Commonwealth
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The Case for System-Level Reform

An Ideological Framework for the Reform Democrats of the New Commonwealth

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The United States built something remarkable: a governing system, a broad middle class, and public institutions capable of keeping concentrated power in check.

That system has been methodically weakened — by corporate interests that found it more profitable to capture government than compete within it, and by an ever-expanding defense economy that continues to consume public resources that could be building the country from within. The result is a country where the cost of living rises every year, the institutions meant to protect ordinary people have been hollowed out, and neither major party has offered a coherent plan to reverse it.

Project 2025 is a detailed governing roadmap for finishing the dismantling. The RDNC framework is the answer — equally specific, equally serious, built around the public interest rather than against it. Not a reaction. A plan.

I. What Was Built, and What Was Taken

The post-war American system was not perfect. But it worked in ways worth understanding, because understanding what worked is the precondition for rebuilding it.

Between roughly 1945 and 1980, the United States maintained a set of institutional arrangements that produced broadly shared economic growth: regulated financial markets, progressive taxation, strong labor protections, public investment in infrastructure and education, and government agencies with genuine enforcement capacity. These were not accidental. They were the result of political choices made after the failures of unregulated markets had become undeniable.

The dismantling of those arrangements began in earnest in the 1980s and accelerated across both parties through the 1990s and 2000s. It was not a conspiracy — it was a sustained ideological and lobbying effort by interests who stood to gain from deregulation, privatization, and the defunding of oversight. The results are now visible everywhere: healthcare costs that consume an ever-larger share of household income, wages that have not kept pace with productivity for five decades, public agencies that lack the staff to enforce the laws they are supposed to administer, and an infrastructure deficit measured in the trillions.

II. The Three Pillars

The diagnostic question that runs through every RDNC policy position is the same: what does a functioning advanced society look like, and what specifically stands between us and that?

That question — applied consistently — produces a coherent governing model. Healthcare, education, and infrastructure are not separate issues with separate constituencies. They are the three pillars on which every advanced society's broad prosperity rests — and they are precisely what has been most

systematically attacked, corporatized, and neglected over the past several decades. When those pillars are strong, people can absorb economic disruption, take productive risks, and participate fully in civic life. When they are weak — as they currently are in the United States — everything else becomes harder.

The policies in this framework are not experiments. They exist and function in comparable advanced democracies. The question is not whether they work. It is how to build the political path from here to there.

This is the critical point that distinguishes RDNC from both existing frameworks. It is not proposing untested ideas. It is proposing proven ones — and providing the sequenced strategy for implementing them against sustained opposition.

III.

Three Principles

The framework is built around three principles that together define both the diagnosis and the posture:

- 1 The system was built to work — and can be again.**
Healthcare, infrastructure, education, and democratic accountability all function in comparable countries right now. The question is not whether these things are possible. It is whether we are willing to fight for them. This is not a call for something radical or untested. It is a call to do what we already know how to do.
- 2 Corporate capture is the root cause, not a side effect.**
The cost of healthcare, the absence of childcare, the stagnation of wages, the decay of public institutions — these are not accidents. They are the predictable result of policy shaped to serve shareholders over citizens. Naming that clearly is the first step to changing it.
- 3 A roadmap beats a reaction.**
Project 2025 succeeded in part because it existed — detailed, sequenced, ready to execute the moment power was available. The American Renewal Agenda is the counter-roadmap: equally specific, equally serious, built around opposite values. Outrage without architecture changes nothing.

IV.

The Strategic Moment

Structural reform does not happen on a predictable schedule. It happens when the failure of existing arrangements becomes undeniable and a coherent alternative is available. Both conditions are closer to being met right now than at almost any point in recent American history.

Public trust in both major parties is at historic lows. The cost-of-living crisis is tangible and personal for a majority of Americans across party lines. Project 2025's agenda is visibly prioritizing corporate and executive interests over ordinary people — and that visibility is a political opening, not just a grievance.

The opening will not remain open indefinitely. The Democratic coalition, however fractured, is looking for direction. The question is whether a coherent governing vision arrives in time to shape that direction — or whether the vacuum is filled by something worse.

The window is open. The question is whether anyone walks through it.

V.

What the RDNC Framework Is — and Is Not

- **It is not a third party.** It is a governing vision for reform-oriented Democrats who believe the party needs a spine, not a new home.
- **It is not a collection of progressive wish-list items.** Every proposal in the framework is sequenced by feasibility and societal benefit, organized into implementation phases, and accompanied by defense strategies and fallback positions. It is designed to survive contact with political reality.
- **It is not anti-business.** It is pro-competition. The antitrust provisions, the data ownership framework, the patent reform proposals — these are designed to make markets work better for more people, not to eliminate them.
- **It is not anti-military.** It is pro-national-security-broadly-defined. A nation whose grid is vulnerable, whose semiconductor supply chain depends on adversaries, and whose infrastructure is crumbling is not a secure nation — regardless of how large its defense budget is.

What it is: a governing synthesis. A coherent answer to the question of what government is for, translated into specific policy, sequenced into a realistic implementation roadmap, and defended against the opposition it will inevitably face.

A Note on Authorship

This framework was not produced by a think tank, a campaign, or a political party. It was conceived and authored by a private American citizen who looked at the same dysfunction everyone else sees — and wrote down a coherent answer instead of waiting for one to arrive.

It is released freely for public use, discussion, and adaptation. The ideas belong to anyone willing to fight for them. Attribution to the Reform Democrats of the New Commonwealth framework is appreciated but not required.

The full policy framework, legislative sequencing map, and bill frameworks are available as companion documents. This paper is the entry point. Everything else is the detail.

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Ideological Framework Paper · 2026

Developed with the assistance of Claude (Anthropic) for research, structure, and editorial refinement. The ideas, judgments, and authorship are human.